were ‘smoke-screens to help the militant outfits’. Basu reportedly replied that the ‘Tatas would not make claims of this nature and magnitude unless they were true’. Basu pursued the matter with a telephone call and advised Mahanta to meet Ratan to find a way to build trust. There was arguably no political leader at that time who could take Basu’s request lightly. The Assam chief minister agreed for a meeting, preferably in Delhi.

Singh, meanwhile, convinced Mahanta about the futility of pursuing an antagonistic position towards the Tata Group and persuaded him to meet Ratan. According to an article in a business daily, the message sent to Mahanta by Singh was, ‘Just as nobody can believe that Mahanta is anti-national, nobody will be impressed by the Assam government’s charge that the Tata Group is indulging in anti-national activities.’

A meeting was held at Assam House in New Delhi in mid-November. Only Singh, Mahanta and Ratan were present at the closed-door discussions that lasted nearly two hours. During the meeting, Ratan reiterated the group’s commitment to the development of Assam, as also his desire to increase the group’s activities in the state.

The meeting was a success. Mahanta softened his approach and realized that branding the Tata Group as anti-national in the absence of evidence would be counterproductive. On the other hand, much remained to be gained from the Tatas’ increased presence in the state, as it would lead to larger revenues by way of taxes.

Mahanta was already beset by several problems and it made little sense for him to continue with the battle against the Tatas. Left with no alternative, he agreed to resolve the issue. In December 1997, the Assam government and Tata Tea decided to bury the hatchet. Mahanta issued instructions to the officials pursuing various cases against the group to complete their investigations soon. This was how the first significant challenge that the new chairman of Tata Sons had to endure ended.

Some two and half decades later, some of the key officials involved shared their thoughts with me. The former intelligence chief of Assam, Ramachandran, reveals that he had personally questioned Krishna Kumar in Guwahati for nearly three days and had found nothing to incriminate the top Tata Group functionaries. There was no evidence of any payments that anyone in the group, even those at the lower levels, had given to the militants, he adds.